

Module 3 — The Empathy Engine

Module purpose

Many early “behaviour problems” are actually communication problems.

This module helps the owner notice stress, fear, over-arousal, discomfort, and possible illness before the dog escalates.

This is not about diagnosing the dog.

This is about learning when to pause, create space, change the setup, contact a vet, or prepare for trainer support.

What the owner should be able to do after this module

By the end of Module 3, the owner should be able to:

1. Watch the whole dog, not one body part.
 2. Notice early stress and space-seeking signals.
 3. Stop forcing interactions when the dog is uncomfortable.
 4. Understand that growling, freezing, and snapping are communication warnings.
 5. Separate likely routine confusion from possible pain, illness, fear, or distress.
 6. Know when a vet should be contacted before treating the issue as training.
 7. Record useful observations for a vet or trainer.
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Lesson 1 — Read the Whole Dog

Scenario

Your dog turns their head away when someone reaches toward them.

They may lick their lips, yawn, lower their body, move away, tuck their tail, pant, freeze, or avoid eye contact.

A family member says:

“They’re fine. They’re just being dramatic.”

You are not sure whether to keep going or stop.

What the owner needs to notice

Dogs communicate with their whole body.

Do not rely on one sign by itself.

Look at:

- eyes
- mouth
- ears
- tail
- body posture
- movement
- breathing
- distance from the person, dog, object, or sound
- whether the dog is trying to leave
- whether the dog can take food or respond normally

A wagging tail does not always mean the dog is relaxed.

A quiet dog is not always a calm dog.

A still dog may be thinking, unsure, frightened, or overwhelmed.

Common mistake

Looking only for obvious signs.

Many owners wait until the dog barks, growls, snaps, or bites before recognising discomfort.

Earlier signs can be quieter:

- turning away
- lip licking
- yawning outside a sleep context
- panting when not hot
- lowered posture
- tucked tail
- ears pulled back
- avoiding contact
- moving behind the owner
- refusing treats
- freezing

Better decision rule

Read the cluster, not the single sign.

Ask:

What is the dog's whole body saying, and are they trying to create distance?

If several signs point to discomfort, pause.

What to do now

When you notice stress signs:

1. Stop what is happening.
2. Give the dog space.
3. Reduce pressure.
4. Move the dog away from the trigger if needed.
5. Do not punish the signal.
6. Do not force the dog to "get over it."
7. Let the dog recover before trying again.

If the dog relaxes when distance increases, that tells you the previous situation was too much.

Watch for this

Notice whether the dog:

- relaxes when people stop reaching
- eats when the trigger is far away but refuses food up close
- moves away repeatedly
- freezes before reacting
- becomes more tense as interaction continues
- avoids one specific person, dog, object, sound, or handling type

When education is not enough

Seek trainer support if:

- stress signs happen repeatedly in the same situations
- the dog cannot recover after space is given
- the dog freezes, growls, snaps, or bites
- people in the home cannot read or respect the dog's signals
- children or visitors are involved and safety is uncertain

Seek vet advice if:

- the signals appear suddenly
- the dog reacts to being touched
- movement, appetite, toileting, sleep, or energy changes
- the dog seems painful, unwell, or unusually withdrawn

Vet/trainer-readiness note

Before seeking help, record:

- what happened
- where it happened
- who or what was present
- the first body signal noticed

- whether the dog could move away
 - whether the dog accepted food
 - what changed when distance increased
 - whether the issue was sudden or gradual
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Lesson 2 — Stress Signals Are Early Information

Scenario

Your dog licks their lips during handling.

They yawn when visitors lean over them.

They pant in the car even though it is not hot.

They lift a paw when someone bends toward them.

They lower their body when a stranger reaches out.

The dog is not barking or growling, so people keep going.

What the owner needs to notice

Stress signals are information.

They are not bad behaviour.

They may mean:

- "I need space."
- "This is too much."
- "I am unsure."
- "Please slow down."
- "I am not ready for this."
- "I may escalate if this continues."

The owner's job is to respond early, before the dog needs to shout louder.

Common mistake

Ignoring polite signals until the dog escalates.

Another mistake is correcting the signal.

Examples:

- scolding the dog for growling
- forcing handling when the dog is stiff
- pulling the dog closer to a person or object
- making the dog stay while clearly uncomfortable

- punishing barking without asking what caused it
- laughing at fear or calling it “cute”

Better decision rule

Early signals are the cheapest moment to help.

Ask:

Can I make this easier before the dog escalates?

Usually, the first move is to create distance.

What to do now

Use the pause-and-distance rule.

If the dog shows stress:

1. Pause.
2. Reduce the trigger.
3. Increase distance.
4. Lower noise, movement, or social pressure.
5. Let the dog choose whether to re-engage.
6. Reward calm observation if appropriate.
7. End the situation positively before the dog tips over.

Do not flood the dog by pushing them closer to something frightening.

Watch for this

Track the early signs:

- lip licking
- yawning
- panting
- paw lift
- head turn
- body turn
- tucked tail
- ears back
- scanning
- hiding
- shaking off
- refusing food
- sudden stillness
- repeated avoidance

Then track what happens next.

The goal is to identify the earliest warning, not only the final reaction.

When education is not enough

Seek support if:

- stress signs are frequent
- the dog's world is shrinking
- the dog avoids normal daily activities
- the dog cannot recover after the trigger leaves
- the dog escalates to freezing, growling, snapping, lunging, or biting
- the owner is unsure how to keep everyone safe

Vet/trainer-readiness note

Tell a trainer:

- which signals appear first
- what triggers them
- how close the trigger was
- how long recovery takes
- what makes the dog better
- what makes the dog worse
- whether the dog has ever growled, snapped, or bitten

Tell a vet if the stress signs are new, sudden, linked to handling, or occur alongside appetite, sleep, toileting, mobility, or energy changes.

Lesson 3 — Freeze, Growl, Snap: Do Not Punish the Warning

Scenario

Your dog freezes when someone reaches for their collar.

Another time, they growl when a child approaches their bed.
Later, they snap when someone tries to take an item from their mouth.

A person says:

“You can’t let them get away with that.”

What the owner needs to notice

Freezing, growling, and snapping are serious warning signals.

They usually mean the dog is over threshold or feels unsafe.

The immediate goal is not to win the moment.

The immediate goal is to prevent a bite, reduce pressure, and understand what caused the warning.

Common mistake

Punishing the warning.

Punishing growling can teach the dog to stop warning, while the underlying fear, pain, guarding, or discomfort remains.

That can make the next incident more dangerous because the dog may skip earlier signals.

Better decision rule

Thank the warning by making the situation safer.

Ask:

What was the dog trying to stop or avoid?

Then change the setup.

What to do now

If the dog freezes, growls, snaps, or shows a clear warning:

1. Stop moving toward the dog.
2. Do not yell.
3. Do not grab.
4. Do not punish.
5. Create space.
6. Remove people, children, or other animals if needed.
7. Wait until the dog is safe and calmer.
8. Record what happened.
9. Seek help if the warning repeats or safety is uncertain.

If an item is involved, avoid direct confrontation unless there is immediate danger. Use management first: keep dangerous items away, prevent access, and seek professional guidance for repeated guarding.

Watch for this

Identify the trigger category:

- being touched
- being picked up

- collar grab
- grooming
- vet-style handling
- food bowl
- chew or toy
- stolen item
- bed or resting place
- child approaching
- visitor entering
- unfamiliar dog
- pain or mobility issue
- being cornered
- being woken

When education is not enough

Trainer or behaviour support is needed if:

- warnings repeat
- children are involved
- the dog guards food, toys, beds, people, or spaces
- the dog snaps or bites
- the dog is cornering, lunging, or blocking people
- the owner cannot safely manage the situation

Vet advice is needed if:

- the warning is sudden
- the dog reacts to touch
- the dog guards a body part
- there is stiffness, limping, yelping, appetite change, lethargy, vomiting, diarrhoea, or sleep disruption
- behaviour changed after injury, illness, surgery, or medication

Vet/trainer-readiness note

Record:

- what triggered the warning
- distance from trigger
- who was involved
- whether the dog could escape
- whether food, bed, toy, touch, or pain may be involved
- first signal seen
- final signal seen
- whether contact happened
- whether anyone was injured
- how long recovery took
- what changed afterward

Lesson 4 — Behaviour Change May Be Health Information

Scenario

Your dog is suddenly different.

They avoid touch, sleep more, hide, snap when handled, stop eating normally, toilet differently, move stiffly, limp, pant at rest, vomit, have diarrhoea, or seem unusually flat.

You wonder whether they are being difficult or anxious.

What the owner needs to notice

Sudden behaviour change can be health information.

Pain, nausea, illness, injury, dental pain, ear problems, skin irritation, digestive upset, toxin exposure, or medication effects can change behaviour.

A dog cannot explain:

“My ear hurts.”

“My stomach feels wrong.”

“My leg is sore.”

“Touching that area hurts.”

They may show it through behaviour instead.

Common mistake

Trying to train through a health problem.

Examples:

- correcting a dog for snapping during painful handling
- calling a dog “lazy” when they are lethargic
- assuming house soiling is disobedience after a sudden change
- forcing exercise when the dog is stiff or limping
- ignoring vomiting, diarrhoea, appetite change, or collapse
- treating sudden fear as stubbornness

Better decision rule

Sudden change means vet first.

Ask:

Is this new, sudden, physical, or linked to touch, movement, appetite, toileting, or energy?

If yes, contact a vet before treating it as a training issue.

What to do now

Pause training pressure.

Observe and record:

- appetite
- water intake
- toileting
- vomiting
- diarrhoea
- sleep
- energy
- walking
- stiffness
- limping
- panting
- coughing
- scratching
- licking one area
- sensitivity to touch
- yelping
- hiding
- sudden aggression or fear

If symptoms are urgent, contact a vet immediately.

If signs are mild but unusual, contact your vet for guidance rather than guessing.

Watch for this

Vet-first signs include:

- collapse
- seizure
- difficulty breathing
- repeated vomiting
- severe diarrhoea
- blood in vomit, stool, or urine
- suspected toxin exposure
- sudden inability to walk
- severe lethargy
- painful crying or yelping
- swollen abdomen
- sudden aggression linked to touch
- refusal to eat with other symptoms

- rapid deterioration

When education is not enough

This module does not diagnose or treat illness.

Contact a vet when the issue may be medical.

Contact a trainer later if the vet has cleared urgent medical causes and the behaviour continues as a repeating pattern.

Vet/trainer-readiness note

Tell the vet:

- what changed
- when it started
- whether it was sudden or gradual
- appetite and water intake
- toileting changes
- vomiting or diarrhoea
- movement changes
- pain signs
- handling sensitivity
- possible toxin access
- recent diet changes
- recent medication
- recent injury, surgery, grooming, or stressful event

Tell a trainer later:

- what the vet said
- what was ruled out
- what behaviour remains
- what triggers it
- what setup changes have already been tried

Tool 1 — Stress Signal Watch Card

Use this during handling, visitors, walks, vet visits, car rides, grooming, or new experiences.

Early signals

- ☐ Lip licking
- ☐ Yawning when not tired
- ☐ Turning head away
- ☐ Turning body away
- ☐ Paw lift

- ☐ Tucked tail
- ☐ Ears back
- ☐ Panting when not hot
- ☐ Scanning the room
- ☐ Refusing food
- ☐ Avoiding contact
- ☐ Moving behind owner
- ☐ Hiding
- ☐ Sudden stillness

Stronger warnings

- ☐ Freezing
- ☐ Hard stare
- ☐ Stiff body
- ☐ Growling
- ☐ Snarling
- ☐ Air snap
- ☐ Bite
- ☐ Lunging
- ☐ Guarding item, food, bed, person, or space

Owner response

- ☐ Stop
- ☐ Create distance
- ☐ Lower pressure
- ☐ Do not punish
- ☐ Let the dog recover
- ☐ Record the trigger
- ☐ Seek help if repeated or unsafe

Tool 2 — Vet First or Trainer First?

Use this when the owner is unsure whether the problem is behaviour or health.

Vet first

Choose vet first if the issue is:

- ☐ sudden
- ☐ linked to touch
- ☐ linked to movement
- ☐ linked to eating or drinking
- ☐ linked to toileting
- ☐ linked to vomiting or diarrhoea
- ☐ linked to lethargy
- ☐ linked to suspected toxin exposure

- ☐ linked to pain, limping, stiffness, crying, or guarding a body part
- ☐ linked to collapse, seizure, breathing difficulty, or rapid worsening

Trainer first, or trainer after vet clearance

Choose trainer support if the issue is:

- ☐ repeating in a predictable situation
- ☐ linked to fear or avoidance
- ☐ linked to handling
- ☐ linked to visitors, dogs, sounds, places, or objects
- ☐ linked to guarding food, toys, beds, people, or spaces
- ☐ not improving after setup changes
- ☐ unsafe for the owner, children, visitors, or other animals

Both may be needed

Use both vet and trainer support if:

- ☐ the dog is physically uncomfortable and behaviour is escalating
- ☐ the dog has repeated fear or aggression and health factors are unclear
- ☐ the owner cannot safely manage the dog while waiting for an appointment

Tool 3 — Behaviour Change Log

Use this before contacting a vet or trainer.

Date/time	What changed	Trigger/context	Body signals	Health signs	Owner response	Recovery time
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Pattern questions

After three entries, ask:

- Did the behaviour appear suddenly?
 - Is it linked to touch?
 - Is it linked to one body part?
 - Is it linked to food, toys, bed, or space?
 - Is it linked to visitors, dogs, noises, or handling?
 - Does the dog recover when distance increases?
 - Is the dog eating, drinking, toileting, and moving normally?
 - Is the problem improving, unchanged, or worsening?
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Module completion action

The owner can complete Module 3 when they can confirm:

- [] They can watch the whole dog, not one signal in isolation
 - [] They can name at least five early stress signs
 - [] They know not to punish growling or other warnings
 - [] They know when to create distance
 - [] They know when sudden behaviour change is a vet-first issue
 - [] They have a simple behaviour-change log
 - [] They know what to tell a vet or trainer if help is needed
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Module 3 dashboard summary

Current focus

Learn what the dog is already telling you.

Today's action

Watch one interaction and record the first sign of comfort or discomfort.

Capability gained

Dog-reading basics.

Decision rule

If the dog is asking for space, create space before the dog escalates.

Escalation reminder

Freezing, growling, snapping, biting, sudden behaviour change, pain signs, illness signs, or unsafe handling concerns require professional support.

Trainer-readiness output

If problems continue, the owner should be able to describe:

- first body signal seen
- trigger
- distance from trigger
- whether the dog could move away
- whether the dog accepted food
- whether the dog recovered

- whether the issue was sudden
 - whether a vet concern exists
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Internal source map

This section is for repo/source control only. It should not appear inside the learner flow.

Core source base

Module 3 is supported primarily by:

- AVSAB's humane dog training position statement for welfare-safe handling, reward-based approaches, avoiding aversive methods, and recognising stress-related behaviours such as tense body, lower posture, lip licking, tail lowering, paw lifting, panting, yawning, and yelping.
- AVSAB's guidance that boundaries should be taught without fear, intimidation, or pain, and that learners should feel safe and be able to opt out of training sessions.
- AVSAB's statement that veterinarians are part of behavioural care and evaluate whether medical factors contribute to behaviour concerns.
- Earlier Gemini rough scan: retained only as an idea pool and not used as primary curriculum evidence because it included weak or non-preferred sources.

Claims requiring careful wording

Stress signals

Approved wording:

Lip licking, yawning, panting, lowered posture, tail lowering, paw lifting, and tense body can be signs of stress depending on context.

Avoid:

One body signal always means one exact emotion.

Growling and warnings

Approved wording:

Do not punish warnings. Increase safety and identify what caused the warning.

Avoid:

Growling is bad behaviour that must be corrected.

Pain and illness

Approved wording:

Sudden behaviour change, touch sensitivity, movement change, appetite change, toileting change, vomiting, diarrhoea, lethargy, suspected toxin exposure, collapse, seizure, or breathing difficulty should be treated as vet-first.

Avoid:

This module can diagnose pain, illness, anxiety, or aggression.

Trainer role

Approved wording:

Trainer support is appropriate when stress, fear, guarding, or unsafe behaviour repeats and the owner needs help managing triggers and safety.

Avoid:

All stress signs require paid trainer help.

Codex implementation note

Store this as:

```
```text id="9cnrbv" /docs/education/curriculum/03-the-empathy-engine.md
```

Optional supporting files:

```
```text id="fdn2wd"  
/docs/education/tools/stress-signal-watch-card.md  
/docs/education/tools/vet-first-or-trainer-first.md  
/docs/education/tools/behaviour-change-log.md  
/docs/education/research/module-3-the-empathy-engine-source-map.md
```